Route 4 after dark

What changes on 10 January, and what doesn't

Harrowmere Town Council · Public meeting at the Corn Exchange
Marta Lindqvist, Transport Officer

9

people on the average Route 4 bus after 7pm

Counted on board, September to October 2026. The bus has 46 seats.

Route 4 today

- Station – Market Square – Elm Park – Hollins Estate – Fenwick village
- Every 30 minutes from 06:00 to 19:00
- Once an hour from 19:00 to 23:00
- One 46-seat diesel bus in the evening
- The evening service costs £212,000 a year to run. Fares bring in £31,000.

Who rides in the evening

Shift workers (hospital, distribution park)	**41%**
Under 18	**22%**
Over 65	**19%**
Everyone else	**18%**

Survey of 312 evening riders, October 2026. 1 in 4 does not have a smartphone.

What changes

From Sunday 10 January 2027, after 19:00 the fixed Route 4 timetable is replaced by **Hop**: two 14-seat electric minibuses that you book.

Daytime Route 4 stays exactly as it is.

How Hop works

- Book in the Hop app, by phone on 01632 960 114, or at the kiosk in Market Square
- Book up to 7 days ahead, or as late as 20 minutes before you want to travel
- Picks you up at any Route 4 stop, plus 23 new "corner stops" on side streets
- You may share with other passengers; the route bends to fit the bookings
- You get a pick-up time when you book and a text or call if it changes

Hours and area

- Sunday to Thursday: 19:00 to 00:30
- Friday and Saturday: 19:00 to 01:30
- Anywhere inside the town boundary, plus Fenwick village
- Not Aldercote: it is outside the trial area

Fares

Adult single	**£2.20**
Under 19	**£1.10**
Concessionary bus pass	**Free, as now**
Booking fee	**None**

Same fares as the bus. Pay on board by cash or contactless, or in the app.

15 minutes

We aim to pick up 9 in 10 bookings within 15 minutes of the time you asked for.

This is an aim, not a guarantee. If Hop is more than 30 minutes late, that ride is free.

Access

- Both minibuses have a ramp and one wheelchair space
- Please book the wheelchair space by phone, ideally 2 hours ahead
- Assistance dogs welcome
- Room for 2 folded pushchairs
- Drivers will help with bags and with getting on and off

What it costs

	Evening Route 4 today	Hop
Cost to run, per year	£212,000	**£187,000**
Fares, per year	£31,000	**£38,000**
Cost to the council	£181,000	**£149,000**

£32,000 a year saved.

Hop is run under contract by Tarn Mobility: two vehicles, drivers and the booking system.

Small print on the saving

- The £32,000 assumes 52,000 Hop trips a year
- Evening Route 4 carried 47,500 trips last year
- If trips stay at 47,500, fares come to about £34,700 and the saving is about £28,700
- The saving is not the reason for the change. The reason is a better evening service for the same money or less.

What other towns found

- **Wexby** (trial 2024-25): evening trips up 18% in the first year. But 12% of phone bookings were abandoned because the line was busy, until a second call handler was added.
- **Tolland**: scrapped after 14 months. One vehicle for the whole town; the average wait was 27 minutes.

How we will judge it

A 12-month trial, to 9 January 2028. A public review at six months, in July 2027.

- At least 85% of bookings picked up within 15 minutes
- At least 47,500 trips in the year
- At least 75% of riders satisfied

If two of these three are missed, the fixed evening timetable comes back.

What is not changing

- Daytime Route 4
- Routes 1, 2 and 7
- School buses
- Concessionary bus passes
- The last train: a Hop minibus meets the 23:42 arrival at the Station every night. No booking needed.

Dates

1 December	**Phone line and app open for bookings**
8 to 17 December	**Drop-in help at the Library, Tuesdays and Thursdays, 14:00 to 17:00**
10 January	**First Hop evening**
July	**Six-month review published**

Have your say

Comments until 30 November: transport@harrowmere.example, or a paper form at the Library.

The council votes on the final details on Tuesday 8 December.

Questions?